

Houseguest

Lord Abelard Vecna is one of those friends where you're never really sure how you met... or when... or why. Nonetheless he is some of the only company who routinely gives me something new to ideate. So, I enjoy him. Guiltily. A jolt to the system.

He smelled faintly of brine and grave-dust when he arrived, two hours late and entirely unapologetic. So, either he's been recklessly haggling with the drowned again, or he's perfected whatever experiment he hinted at in his last letter. He wouldn't say, of course. Just smirked that little smirk and asked if my "lower laboratories were still intact." I told him "unofficially" with my own little smirk. Vecna is the kind of friend that one should not read into too deeply, or at least not often.

We talked shop over wine. He calls it wine, anyway, though I'm fairly certain it began its life as some unfortunate creature's death throes. But who knows, maybe the poor soul is still chained up and producing "rare vintages" for Vecna's cherished colleagues. It stains my decanters but does keep a conversation pleasantly glib. Later, while lounging in the green chair he insists on claiming, he asked whether my portal waypoint ever stopped "misplacing" travelers. I reminded him that only happened the once, and that the *volunteer* had been statistically unlikely to survive her mission regardless. He countered with: "Certainly not! Not with this tower as a prior." I glared back, poorly masking a grin. While I regret asking his advice on that little project I can't help but find his manner amusing. The man has a way of equating necromancy to cooking: precise steps, cheerful improvisation, and absolutely no regard for the lives consumed in the process. I told him as much, and he laughed, accusing me of hypocrisy. (Fair.) We really shouldn't encourage one another.

Still, it's grounding to speak with someone who understands the basic arithmetic of war. The cost of knowledge is always paid in someone's blood. And blood is always being spilled, so it's better that we choose than let it go to waste.

He left me a gift on the way out. A small orb wrapped in kelp-strings, humming faintly, and firmly refusing to be opened anywhere near the wards. I'll deal with it tomorrow. Or next month. Or never. I should replace that green chair.